REP-036 · Readiness review: Fruit Market as a tabletop game and as a mobile/browser game

Game	Fruit Market (rules version 4 on the preview; 1.1.1 on the live game)
Report date	2026-10-27 16:56 (Asia/Kuala_Lumpur)
Type	Critical readiness assessment. No game change
Request	"rate the readiness of the game ... rate it out 10, be real and critical, rate as both a tabletop and a mobile/browser games, i want to publish both version, physical copy and digital"

How to read the scores. 10 = ready to sell next to good commercial games of this type. 7 = solid, needs polish. 5 = works, but a paying customer would notice gaps. 3 or less = not started or a serious blocker. Scores are my judgement from the code, the test results and the records. **No unfamiliar player has played rules version 4 yet**, and that caps every score about fun or balance.

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1. Headline

Version	Score	One line
Digital (mobile and browser)	**5.5 / 10**	Technically strong and well tested, but the rules changed heavily today, have never been played by people, and the presentation is still small-studio prototype level
Tabletop (physical copy)	**3 / 10**	A good idea on paper, but no printed prototype, no table playtest, and one rule (nightly ageing) that is too fiddly to move by hand

Neither version is ready to publish as a product today. The digital one is much closer.

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2. Digital version

Angle	Score	What's good	What's holding it back
Code quality and cleanup	**7.5**	Strict TypeScript; 92 unit tests plus browser tests in CI; lint clean; only 7 small dependencies; game rules kept separate from the screens and deterministic (seeded)	`game.ts` (953 lines) and `App.tsx` (422) are large; four rule rewrites in two days left leftovers (sprites and names for removed upgrades, old experiments in the balance script, "market pulse" also used as the name of the demand bar); 3 type escapes for CSS variables
Network and server	**7**	Server decides everything; hidden choices stay on the server (leak checks at 0); reconnect, grace period and computer takeover are tested; rate limits and name rules	No backup of leaderboard or stats data; capacity never load-tested; Cloudflare plan unconfirmed; branch protection unconfirmed; crash recovery NOT RUN

Angle	Score	What's good	What's holding it back
Gameplay balance	**4.5**	Catch-up rule works (comebacks 38%); skill ladder now clear (Hard beats Normal 60%)	Computer-only evidence; Big Basket 45% (fair 33%); Cold Room and Juice Bar add nothing; 2-player blowouts 42%; rules changed three times today
Core fun (the hook)	**6** (unproven)	The "open stalls, then the bell" duel is a clear, dramatic moment; freshness gives every fruit a role	Computers rarely undercut (86% of sales near the top price), so the hook may feel flat against them. Only people can confirm the fun
Single-player richness	**6.5**	3 computer levels with personalities; tutorial; daily challenge; Market League; 25 achievements; cosmetics; playtest options	Little long-term goal after the league; 24 customers and 13 events can repeat within a few games; no story or campaign; computers don't bluff or show a style you can read
Multiplayer	**6**	Online rooms with invite links, quick match, pass-and-play, 2–4 players, rematch, takeover when someone leaves	Quick match needs many players online at once (it will often be empty at launch); no friends list, accounts, chat or emotes; no async (play-by-turn) mode, which suits phones
UI and UX	**6**	Phone-first; full-screen decisions; clear stall and price screens with hints; day ledger; colour-blind patterns	Very dense: a price card shows stock, buyer caps, rivals and hints at once; tutorial and How to play were rewritten today and not tested; never tested with new players
Art style	**5**	One consistent cosy pixel style; characters with costumes; day/night table	Sprites are drawn as small text maps: charming but programmer-art level beside commercial pixel games; no key art, logo or store art; little character animation
Theme and identity	**6**	A harbour market with Malaysian names is a distinctive setting	Tone is mixed (Princess, Zombie, Cowboy customers next to a real market); the name "Fruit Market" is generic: hard to search for and hard to trademark
Audio	**3.5**	Sound effects and haptics exist; music can be turned off	Sounds and the one 16-note music loop are generated tones; no recorded audio
Release and store readiness	**4**	Android build in CI; privacy policy; anonymous stats with opt-out; release process with tags	No real-phone testing; no iOS build; store screenshots out of date; no monetisation decision (paid, ads or free); no data backups
Accessibility and localisation	**5**	Colour-blind patterns; large tap targets checked	English only (Malay would suit the theme and market); no text-size option; heavy reliance on small numbers

Digital overall: 5.5 / 10.

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3. Tabletop version

Angle	Score	What's good	What's holding it back
Rules completeness	**5**	Full rules written (`RULES.md`), designed to work without an app	Written as a reference, not a rulebook: no set-up diagram, no worked example turn, no component list, no quick-reference card
Upkeep at the table	**2.5**	Simultaneous crates and prices keep downtime low	**Ageing by hand is the biggest problem.** Every night, every fruit in 4 shops plus the market moves one space: roughly 40–80 cube moves a night, about 10 times a game. Also: waiting customers with part-filled orders, Market Day and Last Call tracking, a five-step tie order
Balance for people	**3.5**	The app's computer tests give a starting point	No paper playtest has ever happened; computer results don't show how people bluff, read and undercut
Components and production	**1.5**	Card counts are known (20 farmer, 24 customer, 13 event, 12 favour, 6 trait, 4 speciality)	No prototype; no card or board art; no price dials or screens designed; no manufacturing quote, retail price or box size
Table presence and theme	**4.5**	A colourful fruit market would look great on a table	Nothing designed yet for the physical look
Play time and player count	**4**	2–4 players; 8/10/14-day lengths	Real play time unknown (my guess is 60–90 minutes for 10 days, which is long for this weight); 2 players is the weakest count (42% blowouts)

Tabletop overall: 3 / 10.

The ageing fix to test first. Replace "move every fruit each night" with **date-stamped crates**. When you buy a fruit, place it on the day track at the day it goes off (for example, an apple bought on day 3 goes on day 10). Nothing moves at night; at dawn you clear the crate for today, and freshness is read from how many days are left. This keeps the same rule and removes almost all upkeep. It needs your approval as a rule change.

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4. The biggest risks, in order

1. **Nobody has played rules version 4.** Every balance and fun score here is a guess until real people play it.
2. **The rules keep moving.** Three changes today. A game needs a frozen rule set to playtest, print and sell.
3. **Tabletop upkeep (nightly ageing)** would put off physical players.
4. **Balance gaps:** Big Basket, dead specialities, 2-player blowouts.
5. **Commercial basics are missing:** name or trademark check, store art, iOS, monetisation, a backup plan.
6. **Online population:** quick match will be empty at launch without an async mode or friends invites.

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5. Recommended path to publish both

Step	What	Why
1	**Freeze the rules** for a playtest round; fix only bugs	Stable target for testing
2	**Digital playtest:** 5 or more new players on the preview; watch, don't help	The only way to learn whether the bell is fun
3	**Paper prototype** with date-stamped crates; play at least 5 times	Proves the tabletop works and gives balance data from people
4	**Balance pass** from both playtests (Big Basket, specialities, 2 players)	Fix what people actually hit
5	**Name, art and audio direction:** trademark search, key art, card frames, recorded sound	Needed for the store page and the box
6	**Digital launch prep:** real-phone tests, backups, monetisation decision, store assets, then a soft launch	Release-ready evidence
7	**Tabletop production prep:** rulebook with examples, component list, print-and-play version, manufacturing quote	Before any crowdfunding or print run

A sensible order is **digital first**. It is the cheapest way to test the rules and gather players, and the app can later teach the physical game.

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6. Evidence used

- Code: 2,097 lines of rules, 3,542 lines of screens, 994 lines of server, 1,408 lines of tests (`main` at `e7e5132`).
- Checks: `verify` and `verify:full` PASS (REP-033 to REP-035); online leak checks 0.
- Balance: REP-033 to REP-035, 300 computer games per test.
- Records: `STATE.md` open items (backups, branch protection, real phones, playtests NOT RUN).